

‘This World Cup will extend the movement for women’s cricket’

Smooth operations, fan comfort, and women’s cricket growth: BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia outlines the **World Cup vision.**

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As India gears up to host an ICC Women’s ODI World Cup after 12 years, the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) is leaving no stone unturned to ensure the showpiece event is a success.

The tournament will also be the first ICC event at home since Jay Shah took charge of the global body, and BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia believes the month-long spectacle will inspire budding women cricketers to take up the sport.

To set the tone, the opening day in Guwahati will feature a cultural flourish. Noted singer Shreya Ghoshal, who recorded the tournament’s anthem *Bring it Home*, will perform live. The Assam Cricket Association and the BCCI are also planning a tribute to the late singer Zubeen Garg, a music sensation and cricket enthusiast from Assam who recently passed away in Singapore. “There is a huge grief and tragic situation prevailing in Assam, following Zubeen’s death... the Assam Cricket Association and the BCCI will have a tribute programme during the opening ceremony,” Saikia says. The 40-minute show will feature some of India’s biggest names in music performing Garg’s most popular numbers. “It will be possibly the biggest tribute a cricketing fraternity can offer to him,” he adds.

Being a former First-Class cricketer himself, Saikia knows it is no small feat to stage a tournament of this scale across five venues — Navi Mumbai, Indore,

Guwahati, Visakhapatnam, and Colombo — during a prolonged monsoon season. Yet he is confident the BCCI will deliver.

“As far as the tournament is concerned, the BCCI is fully on the job. Whatever we have planned is going in the perfect line. All the verticals are being checked regularly, and we are ensuring everything is on time,” Saikia tells *Sportstar*.

This year, several parts of the country, including Mumbai and western India, have seen early and persistent monsoon rains. That has complicated preparations, but organisers are optimistic. “As far as the weather is concerned, this is the last part of the monsoon, and this time, the country is receiving too much rainfall, and there is a prolonged and extended monsoon. But in spite of that, venues like Guwahati and others are getting ready for the event. The grounds and the wickets are being taken care of, the stands are ready,” Saikia says. “Whatever infrastructure things have to be done, everything is on. We are perfectly ready to host the